PO33Q - The Life and Death of Democracies and Autocracies: A Quantitative Perspective

Assessment Regime 2026/27

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1 | Introduction

The assessment procedure of PO33Q conforms to the standard pattern for third-year modules set out in the PAIS Undergraduate Handbook. There will be a formative, 750-word research proposal, due in Week 5 of Term 2. The first summative assessment on this module is a fully annotated RScript in which you set out the preliminary analysis for the final summative research project. This component is worth 10% of the overall module mark. The main summative assessment of the module, worth 90% of the overall module mark is a research project of 3,000 words, due at the beginning of Term 3. For this research project, you can either choose the pre-approved title set out below, or, alternatively, you can negotiate your own title. If you negotiate a title with the module director you must submit a title form to the course support team by Friday, February 26th, 2027, 12 noon (the Friday of Week 7). A negotiated title must be more than just a minor rewording of an existing title from the Assessed Essay title list. Please do not leave this to the last minute.

As an assessment in the form of a research project is the exception rather than the rule in PAIS, I have written some guidance as to how the PAIS UG Marking Criteria translate to the world of a research project. We will discuss this guidance over the course of the module, so that you are clear about my expectations. You can download the document from the module's online companion.

Please also familiarise yourself with my guide to writing an empirical research project before you start writing your research project. The deadlines for assessment submission are as follows:

- Research Proposal (formative): February 10th, 2027, 12 noon
- Negotiated Essay Title: February 26th, 2027, 12 noon
- Fully Annotated R Script (summative, 10%): March 17th, 2027, 12 noon
- Research Project (summative, 90%): May 5th, 2027, 12 noon
- Part-Year Exchange Research Project (summative, 100%): March 17th, 2027, 12 noon

2 | Formative Research Proposal, 750 words, Term 2, Week 5

Students are expected to write one 750-word non-assessed formative essay for this module. There is no separate list of titles for this assessment, as you should approach the proposal with your summative assessment already in mind. The expected components of the proposal are set out below, but three are worth placing special emphasis on:

- The proposal (as well as the summative report) must contain a clear empirical puzzle. Here, it is not sufficient to say that the topic is important or timely. You need to juxtapose the expectation that theory or intuition generates with the observation that violates it.
- This puzzle leads naturally into a gap in the literature you are proposing to address. You need to explain why this gap has persisted, and what answering your research question will contribute to the field. A newer release of a familiar dataset is not a substantive contribution; data the field has not used, or a theoretical or methodological move it has not made, is.
- Another central decision concerns the research question you are proposing to answer in the summative report. You can either investigate whether a *level* change in democracy has occurred (suggested measures are either Polity V (Marshall & Gurr, 2020), or the VDem Liberal Democracy Index (Coppedge et al., 2025)), or you can focus on *transitions* between regime types, in which case you will need a binary coding of democracy (suggested measures are either the Boix-Miller-Rosato Index (Miller et al., 2022), or a recoded version of the Regimes of the World (RoW) index from VDem (Coppedge et al., 2025)) as your dependent variable. This choice shapes your hypotheses and your method, so it should be made before you begin drafting.

You can choose your own region (or group of countries that have been motivated through a most similar systems design), but please discuss your choice with the module director, as some regions pose particular difficulties that you need to be aware of before committing yourself. The report must be no longer than 750 words and should be accompanied by an adequate list of references.

It is important that you take this proposal seriously. You can, of course, change your mind about the region, the research question, or indeed anything later on. It is not a requirement that you stick to what you proposed at this stage in the summative assessment. But the clearer you think this through now, the stronger your summative project will be.

The non-assessed research proposal needs to:

- be structured according to the research design provided in the summative section below
- cover all stages up to and including data (use sub-headings)
- contain a clear articulation of the puzzle
- clearly state the research question
- identify a substantive gap in the literature
- contain a clear rationale for the region
- contain a clear rationale for the theory selected
- indicate the causal theoretical chain you wish to investigate
- contain a table which maps concepts to attributes to measures and provides a rationale for the choice of variables over others
- be written in the form of bullet points (note: formative only, do not do this in the summative)
- contain an indicative list of references of at least 15 unique items

The submission date of the proposal is February 10th, 2027, 12 noon – Wednesday of Week 5 in Term 2. You will receive extensive written feedback for this proposal during Reading Week, but no mark. I will also discuss the feedback with you in person in Week 7. You are required to make an appointment with me for this via my booking page. This is the primary form of information on your progress in the module during the term, but please do not hesitate to regularly come to office hours, as well.

3 | Summative Components

3.1 Fully Annotated R Script (10%)

This R Script assessment forms the preparatory analysis of your summative research project (see Subsection 3.2). You may deviate in the summative report from what you have presented in this RScript, but it is essential that you are writing this R Script in such a way that it conducts a theoretically and methodologically sound analysis of the data in relation to your research question. The code must be fully reproducible. Add all explanations using # comments in the script. The R Script must contain the following elements:

- A statement of the research question, for example

```
# RQ: Has economic and social development led to democratisation in the ASEAN?
```

- A statement of the hypotheses to be tested, for example

```
# H1: As a given country gets more economically developed, it tends to become more democratic.
# H2: As a given country gets more socially developed, it tends to become more democratic.
```

- An outline of how each concept is operationalised, for example

```
# Concept           Attribute     Measure
#
# Development       Wealth        gdppc
#                   Health        life
#
# Unearned Income   Rents         natural
```

- Manipulation of the raw data into a format suitable for the analysis, including cleaning, reshaping, and construction of the variables identified in the operationalisation step above

- A preliminary model building strategy, reflecting the theoretical causal chain, and the hypotheses to be tested.

- Estimation of an appropriate statistical model. The model must be one of: (a) a country fixed-effects model with Driscoll–Kraay-corrected standard errors; or (b) a Markov Transition model estimated with Correlated Random Effects and standard errors clustered by country. If you wish to choose a different method, you must discuss this with the module director before submission. Your alternative method must match the statistical sophistication of the two standard methods employed on this module.

- A results table produced using the `modelsummary` package, with correctly labelled coefficients and corrected standard errors (Driscoll–Kraay or country-clustered, as appropriate) passed to the table. You are not permitted to report the model defaults. The table needs to be written to suit the format of your research report (direct inclusion in Quarto, or exported for use in another piece of word-processing software)

- An interpretation of the preliminary results, annotated directly in the script using # comments beneath the `modelsummary` output, addressing the direction, magnitude, and significance of key findings in relation to the hypotheses stated in your research design. The interpretation must not exceed 300 words.

The submission format of this assessment component is a single annotated `.R` file. It is due on March 17th, 2027, 12 noon (Wednesday of Week 10).

For the marking of the annotated R Script, please refer in particular to the descriptors provided in the Scientific Coherence & Rigour, and the Coding pillars in the Marking Guidance.

3.2 Research Project (90%), 3000 words

For the assessed research project, you are encouraged to extend the formative research project you submitted in Week 5 of Term 2. The deadline for submitting the summative research project is May 5th, 2027, 12 noon; if you are a part-year exchange student, the deadline is March 17th, 2027, 12 noon. Your project should draw on the required literature, the lecture presentations, and the material in the module's seminar companion. You are expected to make use of one of the data sets provided. You will choose your own region (see Subsubsection 3.2.1) and construct your own research design, working through the essential elements of the research cycle as outlined in Subsubsection 3.2.2. Include a reference list covering the theoretical, conceptual, and methodological literature, together with relevant work on your chosen region.

The analysis underlying your report must use one of the two methodologies taught on this module: a Markov Transition model with Correlated Random Effects and country-clustered standard errors, or a country fixed-effects model with Driscoll–Kraay-corrected standard errors. An alternative methodological approach is only acceptable if you have agreed this with the module director (as described below). Your results must be presented in a `modelsummary` table that reports the corrected standard errors rather than the model defaults. If you choose the route of the Markov Transition Model, then the inclusion of standard errors derived from the fully-interacted joint model is optional.

You must also provide the R code that takes the reader, in a fully reproducible manner, from the data sets provided on the module's seminar companion to every result in the report. Should you merge variables into the existing data sets, you must include the relevant code for this. You may provide code either as a separate .R file, or by submitting your .qmd file alongside the rendered pdf file if writing in Quarto. Do NOT place the code into the appendix of the report. The statistical code does not count towards the word limit, but it is assessed under the PAIS UG Marking Criteria with reference to the marking guidance document.

3.2.1 Pre-Approved Research Project (approval by External Examiner pending)

This Subsubection outlines the design of a research project which should be adopted for your summative assessment. You may also devise your own title, but as explained in the introduction of this document, it must be significantly different from the instructions below. You are required to negotiate the title with the module director during Week 7 of the module, following receipt of the feedback for the research proposal. You must then submit the completed negotiated essay title form by Friday, February 26th, 2027, 12 noon.

Title
The Life and Death of Democracies and Autocracies: A Comparative Study of <group of countries>.

Instructions

- Choose a region (North Africa, sub-Saharan Africa, Latin America, or a specific part of Asia) or a group of countries motivated by a most similar systems design
- Identify an empirical puzzle with reference to a chosen theory of democratisation, and derive a research question from it. The puzzle should juxtapose the expectation that the theory generates with the observation that violates it.
- Write a research project following the research design outlined in Subsubsection 3.2.2.
- It is imperative that you write this assessment with the geographical region in mind, providing context in the literature review, as well as in the discussion. Please consult the reading list on Talis and the module's full bibliography for some literature suggestions for your group of countries.

3.2.2 Research Design

Introduction

- State the puzzle, for example by juxtaposing the expectation that theory or intuition generates with the observation that violates it. This is not the same as saying the topic is important or timely
- Derive the research question from the puzzle
- State the gap your research addresses, and why it is important to fill it
- Outline the plan of the study
- State the main findings

Literature Review & Theory

- Synthesise the relevant literature: weigh and connect the sources against one another, rather than summarising them one at a time
- Show that the gap follows from that synthesis; where you can, diagnose *why* the gap has persisted — what the field has lacked
- State what answering the question will contribute, and along which dimension: data, theory, or methodology. A newer release of a familiar dataset is not a substantive contribution; data the field has not used, or a theoretical or methodological move it has not made, is
- State the causal chain of your theory, so that every later step of the design can be traced back to it

Hypothesis

- State the hypotheses you are testing, each following from the causal chain. Sub-hypotheses are premissible:
  - H_1:
    * H_{1a}:
    * H_{1b}:
  - H_2:
    * H_{2a}:
    * H_{2b}:

Conceptualisation & Measurement

- State the concepts your theoretical chain invokes, and the attributes of each
- Choose measures that capture those attributes — and *only* those attributes. A single index may legitimately measure several attributes at once (as the Boix–Miller–Rosato index below measures both participation and contestation); what matters is that the measure captures neither more nor less than the concept. A measure that smuggles in part of another concept is where *drift* begins (see marking guidance)
- Check the climb in both directions: every concept reaches a measure, and every measure answers back to a concept. If you cannot climb back from a variable to the attribute it was chosen for, the concept has drifted
- Where a real choice exists — where the theory underdetermines the choice — say why you chose as you did
- It is often advantageous to summarise your choices in a table like Table 1 to supplement the text.

Table 1: Conceptualisation and Measurement

Concept	Attribute	Variable
Dependent Variable		
Democracy	Participation Contestation	Democracy index (Miller et al., 2022)
Independent Variables		
Economic Development	Wealth	per capita GDP
	Growth	per capita GDP growth
Social Development	Health	life expectancy at birth
	Education	primary school enrolment
	Urbanisation	% of population living in cities

Data & Methodology

- State (and reference!) the original sources from which the data were obtained[1] and explain the composition and structure of the data
- Explain the country selection and how this translates to a most-similar systems design
- State your selected method, explain how it works, and why it is suitable *for testing your hypotheses* — the justification should point back at the causal chain, not stand on its own

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≈ half of the word allowance

Analysis

- Test the hypotheses
- Interpret every result in plain English, insignificant ones included: a null finding is a finding about the theory, not a failure of the study
- Claim exactly what the results support — neither inflate a weak result nor hedge a clear one into nothing
- Answer your research question

Discussion

- Relate your findings to the existing literature, explaining how your results support, contradict, or qualify the findings of others
- State which gap the study has filled and what this means for the field
- Discuss reasons why you obtained your results:
  - Why might coefficients be insignificant?
  - What alternative explanations are there?
- State what your design cannot rule out — your *limitations* — tying each to a feature of the design, not to your circumstances. A small sample forced by the research design is a limitation; "I ran out of time" is not
- For each limitation, explain how it narrows what may be concluded, and how it may be resolved by specifying what evidence would close it

Conclusion

- State what the study has done
- State the main findings, and answer your research question
- State which gap the study has filled
- Say what your answer does to the theory: which of its propositions survive, which it qualifies
- Draw the next question from your answer and its limitations

3.3 Part-Year Exchange Students

The same instructions as outlined in Subsection 3.2 apply to you, with four important exceptions:

1. The research project makes up 100% of your overall module mark, rather than 90%.
2. You are not required to submit a research proposal in Week 5, but I would nonetheless strongly suggest you do. This will ensure you are on the right track. As you will receive feedback for this proposal in Week 6, you will have sufficient time to work my feedback and suggestions into your final research project.
3. Your word-limit for the summative research project is 1,500 words. Please get in touch with me to discuss how to compress the full research project into this shorter word count.
4. The deadline for submission of the research project is Wednesday, March 17th, 2027, 12 noon.

[1] For the provided data sets the sources are: Coppedge et al. (2025), Marshall and Gurr (2020), Miller et al. (2022) and World Bank (n.d.) — you are welcome.

List of References

Coppedge, M., Gerring, J., Knutsen, C. H., Lindberg, S. I., Teorell, J., Altman, D., Angiolillo, F., Bernhard, M., Cornell, A., Gjerløw, H., Glynn, A., Grahn, S., Hicken, A., Kinzelbach, K., Marquardt, K., McMann, K., Mechkova, V., Medzihorsky, J., Neundorf, A., ... Sundström, A. (2025). V-Dem Dataset v15. https://doi.org/10.23696/VDEMDS25

Marshall, M. G., & Gurr, T. R. (2020). Polity V Project: Political Regime Characteristics and Transitions, 1800-2018 [Available online at https://www.systemicpeace.org/inscr/p5manualv2018.pdf].

Miller, M., Boix, C., & Rosato, S. (2022). *Boix-Miller-Rosato Dichotomous Coding of Democracy, 1800-2020*. https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/FENWWR

World Bank. (n.d.). World Development Indicators. https://datacatalog.worldbank.org/dataset/world-development-indicators